

LOCAL NEWS MARCH 4, 2011

LIBRARY COLUMN: A look at access services for Latah libraries



George Williams



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My official job title at the Latah County Library District is access services manager. This means I have a lot of people ask me, "So, what exactly do you do?"

The simplest answer is that at most libraries the person who used to be called the circulation manager may now be called the access services manager. It's more complicated now than just checking things in and out. Since I just gave my department's annual report to the library's board of trustees, I thought I'd take a few minutes to try to explain what it is access services does.

First off, access services does in fact handle all of the circulation for the library district. In fiscal year 2010 at the seven public libraries in Latah County we checked out and renewed 293,273 items and checked in 277,502 items. Checking things in and out really is the bulk of what we do.

But we also facilitate patron access to items between our district and the rest of the VALNet consortium libraries. More than 40 public and school libraries just to the south of Latah County are VALNet members. In FY 2010 we shipped 30,856 items from our libraries to VALNet libraries and we received 30,075 items on our end. That's a lot of scanning, crating, lifting and shelving.

Access services also handles shipping items between the seven libraries in Latah County. We don't keep statistics on all of the items we ship and receive within our system but it's a lot of stuff and there are two types of movement that account for it. First of all we ship items between our libraries that people have requested and items which have been checked out at one library and then returned to another. That's the magic of picking up and returning your materials at any library location.

But we also rotate items between our libraries regularly. The district buys new materials all the time. Usually new hardbacks spend four to six months shelved in the new books section at the Moscow branch. Of course, they also move out in response to patron hold requests pretty frequently during that time. After that initial period those books are rotated to each of the six other branches for three to four months at a time. Similarly we try to move DVDs and audiobooks from library to library two to three times per year. Our patrons like to browse their local shelves for ideas and we work hard to make that interesting.

Another primary job we handle is creating new library accounts for patrons. In FY 2010 we created 2,180 new accounts. We also update patrons' account information on a yearly basis. If you have a library card, every year on your birthday your account information expires so we can check to make sure we have your current address, phone number, and e-mail address. We need to be able to contact you when an item you've requested arrives or when you have something overdue.

More importantly, though, access services staff are the people you are most likely to see at the library, particularly at the Moscow branch. They are the people who work at the circulation desk, shelve books and movies, supervise volunteers, and help you place a request in the online catalog. From time to time, they may also be the people who unplug toilets, help you get your car out of the snow and, in one instance, open a pickle jar for you that nobody else could get open.

Currently there are 23 employees and substitutes in this department to help you access library materials. Come by any of our Latah County libraries and we'll try to help you find what you need.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

